

# CLAUDE CODE ROUND — FIELD CHEAT SHEET

Oracle · Forward Deployed Engineering · AI Data Platform | Live agentic-build round — Syed Bukhari

You are graded on **judgment**, not whether the code runs. Drive loud. Plan before you prompt. Verify before you trust. Read every diff.

EXPLORE → PLAN → SLICE → VERIFY → REVIEW → ITERATE

The whole round is this one loop, run out loud. Never skip straight to “implement.”

## FIRST 90 SECONDS — BEFORE THE KEYBOARD

- Restate the requirement in your own words.
- Name the scope — and what is out of scope.
- State your assumptions out loud.
- Sketch the attack: *contract first, then logic, then tests.*
- **This alone beats 80% of candidates.**

## SETUP — DON'T FUMBLE MECHANICS

- Latest Claude Code installed; run `claude`, read `/help` once.
- `/model opus` then `/effort xhigh` — the intended setting for agentic coding.
- Know `/model sonnet` / `haiku` exist; cheap exploration → Haiku.

## LIVE COMMANDS — KNOW COLD

- **Plan mode** — `Shift+Tab`. Proposes the approach before destructive work.
- **Subagents** — “use a subagent to explore X.” Isolated context, returns a summary.
- **Checkpoints** — every prompt is a restore point. Roll back, don't fight a bad slice.
- `/clear` — wipe context between distinct phases.
- **CLAUDE.md** / `/init` — project conventions file.

## OVERRIDE MOMENTS — CATCH ON SIGHT, INTERRUPT

- Hallucinated API or method that doesn't exist.
- Wrong library version.
- String-interpolated SQL — injection risk.
- Missing null / empty-input guard.
- Hardcoded secret or key.
- Swallowed exception — `catch` with no log or re-raise.
- Tests cover only the happy path.

## NARRATION LINES — SAY THESE OUT LOUD

- **OPENING** — “You want [X]. I'll assume [Y]. I'll scaffold the data contract first, then the logic, then the tests.”
- **EXPLORE** — “I'm using a subagent so codebase reading doesn't eat my main context.”
- **PLAN REVIEW** — “Tasks 2 and 3 are reversed — the model must exist before the API. There's no empty-results task — add one.”
- **VERIFY** — “I don't take ‘tests pass’ on faith — run the suite, show me the output.”
- **DIFF REVIEW** — “This SQL is interpolated — parameterize it.” / “This catch swallows the error — log and re-raise.”
- **CORRECTION (PRECISE)** — “The bug is the empty list returns None instead of the typed empty envelope — fix that.” Never “make it better.”
- **KILL-SHOT** — “Stop — that's a prompt-injection surface. Restructure so untrusted content can't reach the instruction slot.”

## MISTAKES THAT TANK THE ROUND

- One giant vague mega-prompt instead of scoped slices.
- Going silent — silence reads as “the AI is thinking for me.”
- Accepting first-draft output on anything that matters.
- Trusting “it works” / “tests pass” with no fresh run.
- Context rot — never using subagents or `/clear`.
- Not reading the diff.
- Vague corrections instead of naming the exact defect and fix.
- Over-building config and abstractions the task never asked for.

If handed Codex: same loop, different keystrokes — say so and run Explore→Plan→Slice→Verify→Review. **You already work this way** — the job today is making it visible and deliberate under observation.